



AP

intentions clear — that he would do whatever it takes to stand atop the podium this year before his Ferrari chapter ends. And he did so unchallenged, as the pole-sitter regained his lead in the opening laps and held it until the end. Verstappen, who momentarily stole the lead, lost it, and possibly the race, after a tussle with Norris.

Whether the FIA modified its rules after a controversial penalty in Austin remains to be seen. However, the stewards had certainly put their foot down this time in Mexico City,

penalising Verstappen with a double 10-second penalty (for causing a collision and staying ahead despite going off-track). Verstappen dropped to the bottom, climbing back to sixth but at the cost of wearing out his tyres too early. Leclerc again capitalised on the battle ahead but eventually settled for third behind Norris.

The sight of Ferrari flags flying high far from home at an iconic part of the Autódromo Hermanos Rodríguez circuit in Mexico City must have brought chills to the

Italian faithful (tifosi).

The podium, surrounded by thousands of fans singing loudly in Spanish, lit up as Sainz ascended with his winning car (**above**) and took to the top step in what could be his final yet most memorable win for Ferrari.

Though the back-to-back race weekends did not disappoint, Norris's ambitious title hope fading away in a race that shifted gears too many times will be a hard pill to swallow. Nevertheless, with three races left in the season, there could still be a twist in the tale.

MotoGP



Down to the wire

The title fight between Jorge Martín (**behind**) and Francesco Bagnaia (**front**) will head to the final round of the 2024 MotoGP season, as the latter defended his pole position to win in Malaysia. The two-time champion managed to keep Martín behind him despite several attempts, reducing the lead in the drivers' standings to 24 points.

Bagnaia showed he wasn't backing down from the battle as he dominated Friday's practice session and broke the pole position record at Sepang on Saturday. Heading into the weekend with a 17-point gap, the sprint race saw the Ducati driver lose the lead in the first lap and crash in the third, gifting Martín the win and a crucial 12 points.

But the Italian rider went into Sunday with unwavering confidence, vowing to go all out in the race.

Despite a chaotic start and a reduced 19-lap event, the lead continuously swapped hands between the title rivals, but Bagnaia pulled away just enough to keep the battle alive. The season is set to conclude at Barcelona's Circuit de Catalunya-Barcelona, as the Valencia Grand Prix was cancelled due to catastrophic flooding in the region.



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